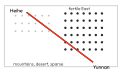
INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

China's development vs Africa

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

China · secured by geography

01 Agriculture + geographical features



> *"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"* PP. 53–54

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the…

SIGNIFICANCE. The most important factor: a great power now confident that it is secured by…

02 Borders + buffer zones



> *"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"* P. —

China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on…

SIGNIFICANCE. Security bought by the buffers frees money for development, but at the…

03 Naval exploits + sea navigation



> *"A green-water navy patrols its maritime borders"* P. —

A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide…

SIGNIFICANCE. The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and…

Key insights

SIMILARITIES

Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and borders they did not choose, and both face pressure from fast-growing populations on limited farmland.

DIFFERENCES

One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle.

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?

Africa in area, China in use

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On size and resources Africa should be the giant; on connected, usable geography China is.

WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?

Unity was cheap

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

1 in 4

Africa's population challenge — p. 217

Africa · prisoners of geography

01 Natural barriers



> *"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"* P. 170

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and…

SIGNIFICANCE. Geography as a whole is underestimated; it explains much of Africa's…

02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war



> *"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"* P. —

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and…

SIGNIFICANCE. Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking…

03 Population growth



> *"One in four people will be African"* P. 217

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and…

SIGNIFICANCE. Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which overall hinders…

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.